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THE BEING OF INSTITUTIONAL LOGICS?

Notes for a Religious Institutionalism Without God

ROGER FRIEDLAND

It is the constellation of being that is uttering itself to us.

MARTIN HEIDEGGER, "THE TURNING"¹

INSTITUTION BECKONS AS A WAY FOR SOCIAL THEORISTS TO CONFIGURE SOCIETY without assuming an ordered, coherent, consensual whole, a bounded collective entity. Institution beckoned to me as a religious phenomenon. In my own approach I had formulated the concept of institutional logic, a network of acts and actors, both human and nonhuman, which sustain and are sustained by linked modes of being and doing, and thus of forming subjects and objects. I first figured institutional logics as polytheistic phenomena while working in Jerusalem in 1983–1984. Within its crenelated stone walls, the Israelite Temple once stood, with its veiled and heavily gilded cubic "Holy of Holies," one of the fullest empty spaces in the world. I am not an observant Jew, but wherever I walked in the city, that razed platform on which the al-Aqsa mosque and the Dome of the Rock now stand, that no-longer and not-yet there, was my point of orientation. For the Israelites the Temple had not been a representation of divinity; it was a site, a dwelling-place, for its absent presence to be available as invisible, unspeakable, unmeasurable, inaccessible in an empty stone box of possibility, uniquely filled with divine being. Pilgrims claimed they could see His fibrillating light there. In the main, if they could, people listened to liturgy. They saw nothing. The Holy of Holies, into which only the high priest was allowed to enter once a year on Yom Kippur, the "day of atonement," the day Jews asked God for forgiveness for their personal sins, was kept in darkness, just as Moses encountered God in a dark smoky cloud that blanketed Mt. Sinai. As the earliest Kabbalist Iyyun sources from the thirteenth century declared: "infinite light lies hidden within the mysterious darkness."² One can never know the oneness of God without seeing the unseeable blackness.

It was here in Jerusalem that I first focused on a new institutional project forming around us, and not just here around this rocky redoubt. The assemblage of a set of practices was steadily creating a new kind of worldhood: religious nationalism, a hybrid of

largely theist religions and exclusionary and expansive nation-states, whose righteous violence, patriarchalism, particularism, and derivation of national identity, state authority, and law from sacred—typically revealed—texts was just starting to shake the world order, in my country too.³

The modern nations of Israel and Palestine had both been imagined and assembled into collective form in the early twentieth century through their historical and imaginary relation to this central site.⁴ More and more, it was through the sight of that platform that each people would see themselves and each other. In Israel, the Gush Emunim, “the bloc of the faithful,” fused messianic Judaism and Zionism, seeing the settlement and annexation of all the lands conquered in the 1967 war as divinely obligated collective actions that would speed the coming of the Messiah and the rebuilding of the Temple.⁵ Two decades later, founded in 1987 during the first intifada, or “shaking off,” growing out of younger members of the Muslim Brotherhood in Gaza, Hamas, “the Islamic resistance movement,” fused Palestinian nationalism and radical Islam, seeing all Mandatory Palestine as sacred lands that could not be ceded and jihad as a religious duty, the primary vehicle to defeat and drive out the Zionist aggressors.⁶ Hamas, indeed all devout Palestinian Muslims, consider Jerusalem the first *qibla*, or prayer direction, and the Haram-al-sharif, known by Muslims as the noble sanctuary, as a site from which the Prophet, traveling from Mecca in the seventh century, rode on his magical steed Buraq to the Seventh Heaven where he met many, including Moses and God himself.

Nobody has an adequate explanation for the growing force and reach of this religious nationalist form, and those on offer tend to do hermeneutic violence to the sense of being of those who sustain it, reducing religion either to a political tool for mobilization, or to a cosmological enactment done for its own sake.⁷ And nobody knows what to do about it. While I was working on a historical ethnography of Jerusalem with Richard Hecht, a historian of religions, I was trying to fashion the practices we observed in this multiply sacred city into a template, what my mentor Robert Alford and I would later term institutional logics, constellations of subjects, practices, and objects whose choreography of space, time, and bodies was both practical and meaningful, instrumental and value rational.⁸

It was against this background that I was dissecting Max Weber's essay on value spheres as heterogeneous directions of worldly rejection, which Weber posed as a polytheism.⁹ Weber's was a brilliant, even beautiful piece of work; for me it was also a provocation to imagine that the likes of Jerusalem, a multiply sacred center of warring gods, might be everywhere, and not some aberrant site where the laws of social physics did not apply. It was then, in 2013, that Elliot Wolfson entered my life at a recruitment lecture for an endowed chair in Jewish studies at the Department of Religious Studies at UC Santa Barbara. The department was an expanding academic parliament of the gods, the communities of each tradition wanting to be represented through their own academic delegates. One by one they funded their own chairs. Wolfson would be the Jewish totem at the table, the Marsha and Jay Glazer Endowed Chair in Jewish Studies.

Wolfson, too, was working in Jerusalem's shadow, conjoining his lifelong study of Judaism, and kabbalistic Judaism in particular, with continental philosophy, specifically

that of the philosopher Martin Heidegger. At UCSB he would begin toiling on two books: *Heidegger and Kabbalah* (2019), on the unexpected parallels between the Nazi Heidegger's philosophy and the thinking of Jewish mysticism that flowered in southern France and northern Spain in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, and *The Duplicity of Philosophy's Shadow* (2018), a text on Heidegger's Nazism and antisemitism. It was clear that Wolfson is drawn, following Heidegger, to undoing apparent oppositions by holding sameness and difference together. Wolfson daringly applies what he terms "juxtaposition," his rendering of what Heidegger calls *Zusammengehörigkeit*, to explore how Heidegger and the Kabbalists in this way "belong to each other."¹⁰

When Elliot lectured, his words periodically doubled back on themselves or folded into chiasmus, so you had no idea where you were standing. I strained to listen. He spoke of the nothingness of God within the mystical tradition of Kabbalah and the atheism that implied.¹¹ The God of the Kabbalah was without will, without Other, yet the "Cause of causes." When he quoted Azriel of Gerona, the thirteenth-century Kabbalist thinker, on *Ein Sof*, the figure for God before his self-manifestation in the production of the world, it was as if a roadside device had exploded next to me:

The One who brings forth something out of nothing is not depleted, for the something is in the nothing in the manner of the nothing, and the nothing is in the something in the manner of something. . . . The Creator is the principle of identity for every way of faith and way of heresy, for they are identical in the place of the conjunction of his nothing in his something.¹²

As Wolfson put it, the One must "embrace its own other in a unity of opposition that is opposed to any opposition to itself." The distance between transcendence and immanence is undone. "Simply put," Elliot concluded, "*Ein Sof* is outside everything because it is inside everything as that which is outside everything." The parallels were extraordinary; the genealogical goat-tracks between them sparse.

I have not recovered from this beautiful wound. I did not fully understand what was being said, but I glimpsed another way to religious institutionalism, an atheological institutionalism without God. Through Wolfson's studies of mysticism and his apophatic, or negative theological, readings of Heidegger, whose texts are unexpectedly peppered with gods, I began to sense that I could abandon the frame of an anthropomorphic transcendent god and still fashion a religious sociology of institutional practice, mysterious and magisterial, yet prosaic and practical.¹³ I offer this essay as a first crude assay of the possibility that people like me might use Heidegger's language to fabricate a house for institutional being.

I did not expect to discover that this unapologetic, antisemitic Nazi, almost completely ignored by Anglo-American sociologists, is great for thinking the institutional.¹⁴ For Heidegger, thinking in values was anathema. Heidegger thought that "things 'invested with value'" was a useless understanding, ontic attributes that revealed nothing about the being of the thing, the value, or the "good," which would be reduced to worldless things present-at-hand.¹⁵ I did not understand why this had to be so. Heidegger didn't

miss an opportunity to denigrate the vulgarity, the “impurities,” and the inauthentic ground of an ontic sociology.¹⁶ In his discussion of the “dictatorship” of the “they” in *Being and Time*, Heidegger’s master narrative of the public realm, he took pains to insist that it “in no way means to furnish an incidental contribution to sociology.”¹⁷ As I explored this new place questions rose all around me, zigging like flies in a kitchen whose door has been left open to let in uncertain breezes. Had Heidegger, through his existential phenomenology, provided elements for institutional logics of practice? Could we think the institutional constitution of being?

In this short and speculative text I can only offer glimpses of how I might appropriate, translate, or transpose some of Wolfson’s engagements with religious mysticism, phenomenology, and especially with Heidegger’s vast corpus as frames by which to reconsider the mystery of institutional life. As a scholar of Kabbalah Wolfson is comfortable with fiery celestial thrones and chariots that bespeak awesome, unspeakable powers that appear incommensurable with the offices, organizations, and groups that have been the primary elements of my intellectual infrastructure.¹⁸ I spent my academic life looking to glean something from the correlation of attributes of entities. I was trained to explain. Now after Wolfson, I struggle to understand how I might apprehend “nothing.”

THE LOGIC OF INSTITUTIONS

This question of institution is not arcane. We are living it in increasingly fraught and uncivil conflicts, where facts and values have become ammunition that doesn’t work, where a critical few committed to institutional meanings have—so far—saved our republic from collapse, a new force field where fellow citizens face off as friends and enemies, where you can buy guns but the stores have run out of ammo, where truth is not only relative, but unreal, like a childhood fairy tale. Our institutional worlding is up for grabs. In the face of all this, I had imagined, following Weber, that we’re in the midst of a war of the gods, that conflicts between institutional “value spheres” should be likened to “an unceasing struggle of these gods with one another,” an image that shows up in Heidegger as well when he posits that conflict between gods as the source of their “divinization.”¹⁹

My starting point now is institution not as an entity or sphere dependent on or animated by gods on the one hand, nor on a subjective belief that attaches compelling absolute values to material arrangements and practices on the other. My question is whether and in what way the logic of institutions, as regular constellations of practices grounded in groundless institutional substances, can be thought of as godless but nonetheless religious, in the sense that visible practices and invisible substances are co-constitutive, immanently dependent on belief and faith.

In the social sciences the concept of institution has lost its identification with bounded entities like the state, the army, or the church. The focus has shifted from entities to relations, from organizations with hierarchical forms and neat boundaries seeking

to buffer themselves from external uncertainties, to distributed action and practice, from agents to agency, from a realist materialism to a constructivist worlding.

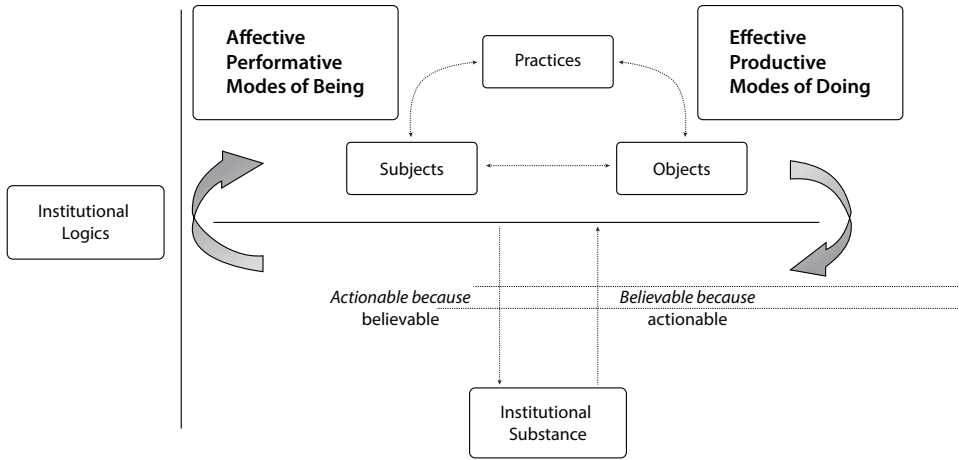
The very category of institution is under erasure. The most significant displacement has been toward the relational field in which “social objects,” argues John Levi Martin, America’s most theoretically sophisticated field theorist, are “sets [or ‘tangles’ or ‘constellations’] of social relations”—whether the IRS or a sexual partner—that we experience as entities or unities able to bear qualities, qualities that “tell us what we are to do.”²⁰ A female “date,” for example, is a social object. In field theory a woman’s desirability, the quality that impels men to “date” her, derives from her desirability as ranked by others, her “popularity as a date.”²¹ This process, Martin and George claim, is what “underlies the ‘sexual capital’ that is equivalent to a consensus regarding desirability.”²² A woman’s attractiveness neither inheres in the attributes of the object, nor the independent subjective preferences of individual men, but is endogenous to the field itself in men’s agonistic relations to each other in their competition for women as potential partners.

Institutions, Martin asserts, are not real entities, but misrecognized second-order refractions of agonistic relations between occupants of differentially powerful positions within a field who maneuver to improve their access to mutually recognized, qualified “social objects.” In his view value is a retrospective “folk theory” of why we are doing something, while institution plays the same role—an “intersubjectively valid representation of the patternings of regulated conduct”—for *what* we are doing.²³ Institutions are shadows on the wall. It is the network of social relations that constitutes social objects.

In sociology institutions are now variously figured as spheres of valued activity, competitive fields characterized by regular repertoires of acts whose premises and promises are a common sense consonantly incorporated and objectified,²⁴ or as taken-for-granted, rationalized myths immanent in rules and consonantly constituted in couplings of types of actor and action.²⁵

Institutional logics are none of these. Institutional logics are neither organizational entities, nor spheres, nor a structure of differentially powerful positions constituting a field.²⁶ They are networks of practices, not positions. Nor, despite a kinship with Foucault’s power/knowledge, are they properly apparatuses, in the genealogical sense Agamben backtracks to the Christian *oikonomia* from Foucault’s *dispositif*, a “set of strategies of the relation of forces,” as that in and through which “one realizes a pure activity of governance devoid of any foundation in being.”²⁷ Institutional logics are not devoid in the way that Agamben claims, but it is what counts as or works as “being” that is crucial to their identification and specification, what they are and how they work. Institutional rationalities, as Heidegger bitinglly accused any kind of practice grounded in the Western metaphysics of presence, are not without content.

Institutional logics are regular constellations of meaningful, material practices, always open, indeterminate, incomplete, self-organizing and thus ever-generative.²⁸ These constellations, and the relational networks of practices that comprise them, afford and depend upon certain modes of bodily being and equipped doing, regimes of affect and effect. The material organization of that practice is afforded and constrained by the



Institutional logics.

corporeality of subjects and by formatted equipment — whether devices or instruments, rules, accounts, codes, sites, languages. In an institutional logic subjects and objects are not external to each other, independent entities that interact; they are active elements gathered intra-actively.²⁹ As Wolfson puts it, they belong to each other. Institutional logics have an immanent intent, an internal telos. They are logics of practice in the sense not of rules of inference, the classical understanding of logic, but in terms of the reproductive regularities of production or enactment of nonphenomenal goods. I call these non-phenomenal goods institutional substances, drawing from Aristotle's later understanding of the term, not from the Cartesian notion of substantiality as an extended thing.³⁰

It was Aristotle and his preoccupation with the analogical unity of being, of is-ness and as-ness, that early on set Heidegger on his way to a phenomenological rereading of his work.³¹ Substance, his translation of *ousia*, or being, was central to Aristotle's lexicon. Heidegger rather understood the “substance” of man as existence, as standing out “in the openness of being.”³² For Aristotle a substance is a “principle” that sustains a kind of determinate being over time, without which it would not continue to exist. That principle is “the primary cause of being” of something.³³ The substance is what enables a thing to persist as that thing even as its attributes change. Unlike Plato, a substance is not an independent idea, hence a being, nor an ideal form; it is an actuality, not a potentiality; and it does not exist independently of that which it is the substance, a form eternally enfolded somewhere in an untouchable hyperspace.³⁴ For Aristotle substance is not a being, but a beingness, both the basis of something's thisness, that a thing can be identified as a particular, separable individual, and its whatness, such that it qualifies as a kind of being.³⁵

Aristotle understands substances as immaterial principles that are “sources of movement,” that initiate causal structures that “produce . . . unity” over time.³⁶ Substance is primordially actuality, not potentiality; form, not matter. As actuality substance is *energeia* and *entelecheia*, the latter a word he coined himself.³⁷ These two terms refer respectively to being at work in the world and to ends-oriented activity or completion.³⁸

Entelecheia's literal meaning is "intrinsic possession of the end."³⁹ Substance thus joins what we conventionally divide: means and ends. It conjoins the two as actualization of a potential and the realization of an end. The end, the for-sake-of-which, is internal to the organization of its production and its product. What a thing is is integrally related to its end, that for the sake of which its activity is done, linking ontology to telos.⁴⁰ Substances are the source of practical movement toward ends, movements that already contain those ends within them.

Institutional substances, onto-teleological fusions, are not transcendent beings, nor transcendental ideas, nor what Heidegger, drawing on Plato, terms the look, the *eidōs*, of their whatness.⁴¹ Institutional substances do, and must have, causal force, but not in Heidegger's sense when he writes of being as "not brought about by anything else nor does it itself bring anything about. Being never at any time runs its course within a cause-effect coherence."⁴² Institutional substances do run their course within the coherent movements of practice that they afford and are afforded by them. Institutional substances are causes of causes, of the directional movements of practice that constitute worldhood. Institutional substances are, as the Kabbalists say of infinity, the "nothing of *Ein Sof*," the cause of causes, constitutive of the productive gathering of subjects, practices, and objects.⁴³ Institutional substances afford the gathering of institutional logics. Although I do not think of them as gods, they have a structural kinship with the polytheistic thought of Proclus, a fifth-century neo-Platonist, who wrote: "In each order or causal chain there exists a unique monad prior to the multiplicity, which determines for the entities ranged within it their unique relation to one another and to the whole. Admittedly, among members of the same series, one may be cause of another. But that which is the cause of the series as a unity must be prior to them all."⁴⁴ Institutional substances unify practices; they afford constellations.

Institutional substances make institutional practices doubly objective—as objectives to be actualized and as actual objects. Institutional logics are grounded in and ground these institutional substances, invisible goods that can never be present, absent presences that are nonetheless preconditions for the appearance, the coherence, and the productivity of the constellations. In Heideggerian terms, the elements of an institutional logic cohere because they belong to each other.⁴⁵ Institutional substances are integral to that belonging. Like the neo-Platonic god they "participate" in the constitution of the constellations. These constellations of practices are intentional movements that create kinds of places, or as Heidegger puts it, "clearings" in which humans with their concerns stand and in which their practices are both intelligible and actionable.⁴⁶

When Heidegger analyzes regional ontologies, his understanding of their practice can have much in common with institutional logics. One example is the ontologically and teleologically specific ways Heidegger discerns the way modern technology "brings what presences into appearance."⁴⁷ Modern technology, he affirms, is no longer a poiesis, a "bringing-forth" out of their earthly concealedness, but a "challenging-forth" in which the "energy concealed in nature is unlocked" and "everything is ordered to stand by."⁴⁸ In this quantitative Enframing, like the nature whose energies we seek to extract, store, and mobilize, we, too, become "standing reserve," a "calculable coherence of forces."⁴⁹

Although Heidegger does not use institutional concepts, he here identifies modern technology's practices as tied to a specific teleo-ontology, simultaneously a final cause and an ontology of matter. That teleo-ontology depends on and affords a co-constitutive subjectification and objectification.

Institutional logics create institutional worlds, or what Heidegger understood as a "referential totality which constitute significance."⁵⁰ Human concerns and purposive things, the institutionally specific potentialities for human being and the affordances of institutional entities, conjointly make the worlds to which we belong and belong to us. Institutional logics are mechanisms of world-formation, paralleled and propelled by intra-active objectification and subjectification that make them ours and place us there. Institutional substances are both the *teloi* and the ontologies of those practices, both the good the practices are understood to produce and the good both immanent in and transcendent to the constellation of practices that presume and produce them, practices that keep that world open to those goods and conceal their presence within them.

Institutional logics are grounded in nonphenomenal goods—like justice, sovereignty, democratic representation, nation, race, love, beauty, knowledge, market value, nature, transparency, information, personality, and, of course, God.⁵¹ These goods are not entities, nor essences, nor just ideas. They are virtual realities immanent in, yet excessive to, institutional practices. Each good has a concealed infinitude, a plenitude of the unknown, the unthought, the unspoken, and the undone, kinds of possibility excessive to its manifold manifestations, a no-thing and a no-body, that which can neither be observed nor touched.⁵² In practice institutional substances open clearings in which an unknown multiplicity of possibilities might be effected. Institutional substances are like the zero, as the mathematician Robert Kaplan titles his book, each *The Nothing That Is*, or as Wolfson puts it, "actual but nonexistent," real and imaginary.⁵³ They are the immeasurable bases of measuring. They are indivisible bases of multiplicitous division. Their incalculability affords the possibility of calculation.

Institutional substances are bases of world-making. The constellations of practices that compose institutional logics manifest the goods; they are not their ground. Institutional logics depend on their substances, typically invoked when the logic forms or fails, when it is challenged by practices premised on another, when what was in darkness casts another kind of light. It is at these points that institutional substances reveal themselves as "nothings," to play with, pluralize, and transpose Heidegger's concept of the "nothingness" of being that bestows being by withdrawing from beings.⁵⁴ These are goods that can never be present, but whose absent presence is responsible for the logic of the logic, that it both means and does something. We know them by our common participation in that doing, by what it does to and for us.

An institutional substance does not fit the Humean division of fact and value, of what and why: it is both an ontological assertion of what is or can be and a valuation, a good toward or around which one can organize some segment of life. By comparison to the presence of things, an institutional substance is an absent presence toward and around which practice incessantly moves, known only through this movement. This is the mysterious core of an institutional logic, the marvel of our doing, that we can recognize and

say that this is that, that institutional substances, the basis of institutional being, give us the is-ness of life that we can take for granted and depend upon to get on with just about everything. In practice, institutional substances are laden with unknown possibilities, including unexpected extensions (that a corporation can be modeled on a legal person; a worker an independent contractor; a chromosome a commodity), as well as the dangers of getting locked into practical, and particularly procedural, idolatry, mistaking the practice of beings for the institutional being of practice.

Institutional practice and substance depend on, but cannot be reduced to, each other. As Gunther Teubner, the German legal theorist, has pointed out, the law depends as much on justice as justice depends on the law. As Teubner writes, "No philosophical theory of justice or other external authority can dictate the normative content of law. It is law itself that puts the law on trial."⁵⁵ The practice of law, through the substance of justice, is always outside itself. Institutional logics are teleo-ontological enactments, a why-what done through a how, popular sovereignty through democratic election, justice through juridical practices that classify actions according to the binary of legal and illegal, divinity through pilgrimage, prayer and sacrifice, romantic love through intimate exchange of body and word. Institutional substances give institutional logics the modes of being appropriate to the presence and productivity of its practices, the real and the good that are immanent in their actualization, the conjunction of the what and why that are fitting to them.

Institutional logics are grounded in the absent presence of a good that affords and is afforded by the space of practice, a kind of there through which bodies become kinds of subject and things kinds of object. That there houses our institutional being; we "are" that there. A particular kind of object, which I term institutional objects, are central to these formations. Institutional objects are good-dependent: accounts, money, property, corporations, economic models, territorial borders, capitals, censuses, information, offices, taxes, passports, parliaments, votes and ballot boxes, altars, sacred centers, communion wafers, revealed texts, altars, experimental results, artworks, and family homes. These are material symbols, not signs. It is through good-dependent objects that the practices manifesting the absent presence of those goods form into constellations. While objects can be institutionalized as to their properties and their uses, most objects are not themselves institutional. Institutional objects are intentional; they have an intrinsic relation to practices through which they become objective, objects intending a good. Institutional objects are like classical icons in that we are seen by them, or more precisely, that our subjectivity is an imaginary site, an invisibility, formed in the relation between us and them, by their invisible sight.⁵⁶ Institutional objects touch us; they move us and we move through the pathways they make possible. The Edenic parable of eating the apple is perhaps a figuration of the first institutional object, through which we looked at ourselves and realized that we are naked. It is the knowing of the good that makes us understand that we can be raw data. Our flesh was the first taboo, the sacred, the set apart that could not be eaten. As subjects we are dual with the apple; lacking it, we are just beasts.

Institutional objects, unlike things or ordinary equipment, are conspicuous, bringing attention to their nature and the look of their substantiality. This is the way Heidegger

writes about “works,” like the three Doric temples at Paestum to Poseidon, Hera, and Ceres built in the fifth century BCE.⁵⁷ Such works, unlike ordinary objects of use, are set up to create worlds; they hold open the Open of that world; they are consequently consecrated; and “the god is present” within them.⁵⁸ Worlding, in Heidegger’s example, is bound to the whole cycle of existence of a historical people; the work gathers the worldhood of a people and its gods. He writes:

It is the temple work that first fits together and at the same time gathers around itself the unity of those paths and relations in which birth and death, disaster and blessing, victory and disgrace, endurance and decline acquire the shape of destiny for human being. The all-governing expanse of this open relational context is the world of this historical people. Only from and in this expanse does the nation first return to itself for the fulfillment of its vocation.⁵⁹

At one level Heidegger’s things and works can be read as institutional objects: here they gather the practices that constitute a nation, an institutional substance. At another level they gather the universal relationality of world-making.⁶⁰ Like works, institutional objects are essential to what we might call the “gathering” of the components of an institutional logic. For Heidegger a gathering that worlds is a building site for the willed collective choreography of existential conditions, not for the play of culturally and practically distinctive institutional substances. Heidegger’s gatherings are existential and relational, but not, by and large, institutional. In his late work, in what he calls “the fourfold” Heidegger speaks of the bridge as a “thing” that gathers the “fourfold”—earth, sky, divinities, and mortals—into the “primal oneness of dwelling.”⁶¹ It is striking that dwelling “preserves the fourfold by bringing the presencing of the fourfold into things.”⁶² In this “mirror-play of the betrothed, each to the other in simple oneness. The fouring presences as the worlding of the world.”⁶³

Being and meaning are tightly linked for Heidegger.⁶⁴ While Heidegger’s divinities in the fourfold are messengers of meaningfulness, no particular meaning is specified.⁶⁵ The problematics are universal existentials, reducing all to a fundamental ontology.⁶⁶ Substantive goods, produced and preserved by institutional practice, are nowhere to be found. It is through particular goods that institutional objects are objective, that they can produce the goods. And it is through these objects that goods are objectified, a signified “this” that is both teleological and ontological, objective in the double sense.

WHAT GIVES?

The dominant sociological understanding of institution is the taken-for-granted “repetitive social behavior that is underpinned by normative systems and cognitive understandings.”⁶⁷ Institutional theorists took the “taken-for-granted” to be the essence of, indeed synonymous with, an institution, referring to conventionally accepted types of actor and action.⁶⁸ In the terms used here institutionalization would be indicated by institutional

substances that ground particular networked sequences of practice becoming so obvious you no longer invoke them or even notice that they are their presuppositions.

The term “granted” offers a conceptual boundary object to interface institutional logics and the worlds of *beyng*. Central to the way Heidegger understands being is as that which gives; playing on the double meaning of *es gibt*, “there is/it gives.”⁶⁹ That givenness, this letting be, this gift of un-concealing, is the mysterious “being of being.”⁷⁰ Being, unlike beings, is not an entity.⁷¹ Beyond representation, it is rather a no-thing, the *Nichts*, “that which is altogether other than all beings, being is that which is not. . . the pervasive expanse of that which gives every being the warrant to be.”⁷² It is not that it is not; it does not “is.”⁷³ Being bestows being by withdrawing from beings, a “fullness of the nothingness of *beyng* that withdraws from all beings.”⁷⁴

The strangest thing happens in Heidegger's philosophical progression: gods, and even God, make increasingly central appearances in the organization of worlding. In his view, Christianity was integral to robbing beings of being. Heidegger mocked the uncreated creator God of Christianity, “the being-est of beings.”⁷⁵ This “creator is the most certain and all beings are the effect of this most extant cause.”⁷⁶ In Heidegger's eyes this Christian idea of God as highest being, ultimate cause, and dispenser of being led to a hegemonic understanding of the human as a created being, *ens creatum*, a being who can be treated as if he were a presence, simply “there,” a rational animal or a generic “life.”⁷⁷ In *Contributions to Philosophy* he explained the result:

Abandonment of beings by being means that be-ing has withdrawn from beings and that beings have become initially (in terms of Christianity) only beings made by an other being. The highest being as cause of all beings took over what is ownmost to be-ing. These beings, once made by the creator god, then became of human making, insofar as now beings are taken and controlled only in their objectness.⁷⁸

Nonetheless Heidegger's texts are peppered with Christian terms, especially his invocation of god and gods. In his *Beitrage, Contributions to Philosophy*, written in 1936–1938, he writes, “A people is a people *only* if it receives its history as allotted to it through finding its god, the god that compels this people beyond itself and thus places the people back amid beings.”⁷⁹ This was written when Heidegger's beloved German nation was then unmaking another people.

God, for Aristotle, is the highest being, the highest good, and the primary cause of all entities. Heidegger's invocation of gods is a question mark, not an assertion. It is certainly not a good, a category he did not use, nor a purpose, a category he abjured.⁸⁰ It is not clear what role gods play in Heidegger's approach, or why he even needs them. He refuses the metaphysical absolute, transcendent, self-sufficient concept of God, the highest and most-being One. Unlike the One who is the source of being, Heidegger's gods are needful; they do not give being; they seem to borrow it. Heidegger insists that gods are not to be “identified with *beyng*.”⁸¹ Being, or *beyng*, is the beyond beings that grants being to beings and gods from the space-time between them.⁸² Being is grounded in *Dasein*, not the gods. “Gods’ need be-ing in order through be-ing—which

does not belong to gods—nevertheless to belong to themselves.”⁸³ Gods are here antisocial forces that “tear humans away from ‘beings’ and that compel being as the ‘between’ [*das Zwischen*] for themselves and for humans.”⁸⁴

How to locate institutional substances? There are, as I have tried to show, elements shared with Heidegger's being. Institutional substances are absent presences that open a space and grant institutional being to and through practice. Admittedly I have pushed hard on the comparison when, in fact, it is difficult within Heidegger's philosophy to commensurate institutional logics into privileged sites for particular kinds, or modes, of being. Heidegger didn't consider goods to be that which is “ownmost to a being (as work, tool, thing, deed, view, and word).”⁸⁵ At the end of his life he opined that human action and philosophy would be impotent to counter our steady machination by the technological world. “Only a God can save us,” he famously declared.⁸⁶ But which god? What good? How? He really had no answers, other than an elitist vanguard willing to jump into the abyss of nothingness to see whether they might become friends once again with the gods. His own life had been a celebration of will. He saw no reason to atone for his murderous choices; he never actually left the Nazi Party. He never considered the ways in which particular goods might afford different constellations of practice that would afford more habitable worldhoods. His project remained the pathetic same: a second beginning to re-form his nation's power.

You take institutional substances for granted because they are granted, or given, to you, and they give you the kind of being that is essential to the operability of that practice. These meanings are the invisible bases of their visibility. Institutional substances are taken for granted not just because they are presumed to be based on what everybody does or knows, the way sociology understands conventions and existential phenomenology understands everyday existence, but also because they are what grants or gives us institutional being, a mode of being that is specific to the practices grounded in that institutional substance. We take them for granted because they participate in what we do and who we are. We are not just social beings thrown into normativity and the functional exigencies of practice; we are institutional beings beyond ourselves grounded in institutional substances, substances that are made manifest in practice that gather us together as kinds of “we” bonded as such through implicit and explicit belief in the invisible substance. We are unified by the common good, or substance, that undergirds the practices that generate our otherwise contentious differential worth.⁸⁷ We are gathered by our common participation in the gatherings institutional logics compose. This is the institutional basis of our truth, the truth of our being.

Institutional substances are the invisible, infinite, incalculable ground of institutional logics. Institutional logics thus both refract and conceal what is beyond saying and their elusive referents. Institutional substances cannot be seen but are the condition of visibility. They will never be objects, but are the condition of objectivity. Although they are categorical, they evoke a collective, institutional counterpart to Heidegger's being, as a giving of an institutional mode of being to beings, which helps make the institutionally logical constellations of subjects, practices, and objects intelligible and

accessible. Heidegger referred to the giving of *beyng*, “something which, to be sure, is not but which must be given if we are to experience and understand beings at all.”⁸⁸ It is out of the not that *beyng* both gives and withholds. Although that giving is manifest in beings and their practices, those manifestations necessarily conceal not only the *beyng*, but its concealment in their revelatory giving, covered up in the uncovering. Wolfson puts it this way:

Beyng conceals itself in the manifestness of beings—hence, *beyng* is present in the very beings from which it is absent, not as an objective thing that is occluded—the invisible—but as the inapparent that can appear only as not appearing, the mystery that is bestowed in the refusal of bestowal.⁸⁹

This kind of story is a plausible account of many institutional genealogies, that money, for example, can successively be cut away from commodities, state authority as fiat money, or banks and financial institutions as blockchain-based cryptocurrencies, and still be understood as measures, media and stores of market value. Or that the Israelite Temple, where God abided, could be destroyed by the Roman legions and the Israelites forced into exile and yet the rites, many of them modeled as transcriptions of Temple practice, would still be understood as enactments of the same religion grounded in the same God.

Institutional substances do not exclude, but exceed objectification, invariant rules, calculability, causal determination. These substances are not phenomenal; the practices that host them, however, are. People, both scholars and ordinary folks, believe that one can get behind their apparent manifestations, reduce them, for instance, to interests and powers. Whether they can or cannot is immaterial; we cannot seem to accept that there are only appearances at work. Institutional substances are always at risk of withholding or withdrawing from existent practices into an abyss, a void, the *ab-ground*, whose emptiness is both a potential source of anxiety and inexhaustible possibility, with what is to become and what will never become.⁹⁰ Institutional substances, as Heidegger notes of the “refusal” of being, “*this* not-character of *be-ing* itself” is part of the “nothing” that *beyng* is.⁹¹ The immanent tendencies of *beyng* to manifest itself in beings as *Dasein* conceal the fact that our most important institutions are grounded in nothing, not only in that which can wither and die, be displaced by others, but most primordially are grounded in a nothing filled with possibility upon which being and non-being both stand.⁹² That gap, that space between, not only injects a wanting and a waiting into making, a love story, a passion to world that impassions us, but also allows those who sense the nothing that grounds their conventions to anxiously feel the threat to worldhood, for others that their making will always be deficient, that exemplarity is forever something to be aimed at, and for a select few the inceptual intimation of something that can not only be intuited or dreamed, but fought for through practical reengagement with the substance. The withholding, the never arriving, is not only a functional structure of desire, for maintaining the sameness in difference, as Wolfson puts it. It

works well because the nonphenomenal substance, the ground of institutional being, kept and keeps us waiting forever, beckoning on the horizon of countless practitioners, thereby allowing institutional logics to perdure and to change and to “maintain the sameness of their difference.”⁹³

THE SUM OF INCOMMENSURABILITIES

Institutional logics are concerned with the nonapparent conditions of appearance, with the inceptual formation of new worlds, with the instituting and organizing force of what is not phenomenal. They put practices at the center of human existence and being. They too are centrally concerned with the relations of meaning, which finds its basis in a kind of being, which cannot be present to present beings whose essence is existence. They, too, posit an atheistic and atheological religious constitution of worlds. They, too, are dependent on yet exceed language, testifying to its foundation in silence, in namelessness, in nothing. In thinking institutional logics there is a move away from the causality of before and after, toward a relational holism, what Wolfson calls a “relational fabric of beings.”⁹⁴ Institutional logics concern the multiple meanings and practical orders of institutional being, both incommensurable and complementary, which cannot be reduced to existence, neither to subjectivity nor objectivity. Institutional logics are mechanisms of worlding, of the formation of fields. Institutional logics are gatherings. And research in institutional logics increasingly cleaves to relational techniques, looking for constellations of practices, not their net causes and consequences as independent or dependent variables.⁹⁵

Institutional logics are effected through the conjunction of metaphysical goods and material practices, in what is beyond the seeable or the sayable on the one side, and what is doable through linguistically mediated discourse and the effects of materially equipped agency on the other. The mystery of institutional life is located in the conjunction of the invisible and the visible and in the practical coherence of the logic, the steady reproduction of these incomplete, inherently unstable alignments, with changing referentiality and changing practices, held together by the assumption of an invisible substance. That substance is located in the transom of practice, a space that affords both the mystery of socially meaningful practice and the implosive catastrophe of meaningless social construction.

Building an institutionalism based on atheistic mysticism, while homologous in many ways with an institutional logical understanding of worldhood, is markedly non-consonant in others. Institutional logics are grounded in teleo-ontologies, their animating principles, and hence have immanent aims or goals. Beyng, its structural analogue in Heidegger's approach, has no goal, no ends. As he wrote in his “Black Notebooks”:

Beyng itself is and only beyng is—and as beyng it is without a goal. . . . The truth of beyng is to be grounded, because this truth belongs to beyng. . . . Because beyng is only the abyssal ground, it has no goals and averts every setting of a goal.⁹⁶

Heidegger adjoins values as the subjectivist slag of metaphysical thinking. Institutional logics, to the contrary, are based on four moments of valuation: institution, production, territorialization, and evaluation.⁹⁷ Institutional logics put the primacy on the production of goods. Heidegger rejects the category of production as a Greek metaphysical approach to being, particularly the production of substantial entities.⁹⁸ He also cuts the legs out from evaluation, construing calculation as a practice yoked to metaphysics, a mode of being from which the new beginning must be “imperishably withdrawn.”⁹⁹ He makes the standard identification of calculation with business whose “unshielded” “assertive man lives by staking his will. He lives essentially by risking his nature in the vibration of money and the currency of values. As this constant trader and middleman, man is the ‘merchant.’ He weighs and measures constantly, yet does not know the real weight of things.”¹⁰⁰ I reject the notion that the economy in general, and capitalist production and exchange in particular, should be set apart as a profane, objectified space of partible goods, instrumental and calculable, as opposed to the noninstrumental “attunement” of poetry, which takes the “mysterious measure” through which “the gauging of the dimension of dwelling” is accomplished.¹⁰¹ And I am repulsed by his racial identification of calculation with the Jews, about whom he writes in his “Black Notebooks,” “with their marked gift for calculation, the Jews ‘live’ according to the principle of race.”¹⁰² In Heidegger’s eyes calculation is of a piece with the Jews’ worldlessness.¹⁰³ The Jews, racially inclined to truck in calculation, neither belong to a “people,” nor to themselves.¹⁰⁴ In contrast to Heidegger, who argues that calculability is a mark and medium of machination, of objectification, of worldlessness,¹⁰⁵ I understand counting and calculation—how many are good and how good is their goodness—as a practice that substantiates the good, apparently making its nothing into something. Production and evaluation cannot be neatly cleaved.

Heidegger has set things up such that goods cannot be gods, as they were for Aristotle and Proclus, for example, nor forms of being, nor beings, but are reduced to present-at-hand things. Heidegger is only willing to accord values the status of an ontical predicate of a thing, such that both values and goods can only be present-at-hand. Heidegger links the two. He writes: “Adding on value-predicates cannot tell us anything at all new about the Being of goods, *but would merely presuppose again that goods have pure presence-at-hand as their kind of Being*. Values would then be determinate characteristics which a Thing possesses, and they would be *present-at-hand*. They would have their sole ultimate ontological source in our previously laying down the actuality of Things as the fundamental stratum.”¹⁰⁶ Value is part of the willing and making of the super-subject that Heidegger sees as part of our perverse inheritance of the ontotheological creator-God who makes beings who take that as a model of their own being, as producers of everything, including themselves. In his “Letter on ‘Humanism,’” he declares that “thinking in values is the greatest blasphemy imaginable against Being. To think against values therefore does not mean to beat the drum for valuelessness and the nullity of being. It means rather to bring the clearing of the truth of Being before thinking, as against subjectivizing beings into mere objects.”¹⁰⁷ Value is part of the grand stratagem to withdraw being from beings. I would argue that value’s excision as a blasphemy

against being robs it of its institutional sources, which are just as mysterious—and in some of the same ways—as Being.

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